

GATHERING WATER

It is blisteringly hot at Chand Baori today, so several women from the nearby village are fetching cool, clean water from the well. It is heavy work carrying pots of water up the steps, but the air is cool and the chance to share news with friends makes up for the steep climb.



Palace of Winds

Avoiding the heat has always been important in India. While village women enjoyed the shade of the stepwell, wealthy women appreciated the cool air behind the latticed windows of palaces, such as this one in Jaipur, which was built in 1799.

A balancing act

Collecting water was such a big part of women's lives that it inspired a style of music called Panihari. Still popular today, it is sung by women while dancing with pots on their heads.



It is always women who collect water, not men.

The narrow steps lead down to the fresh, clear water of the well.

The water level rises and falls as groundwater levels vary over the seasons and years.

Music at the well

On market days and festivals, large groups of people met at the stepwell. Traveling troupes of musicians playing pipes, drums, and string instruments may have entertained them.

